

Collective Security

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Government, whether on the world level or the city level, implies a permanent set of officials and permanent rules in the form of codified laws. But even when such institutions are not available, limited forms of governance are possible. In the American "Wild West," there were towns without a government in the form of a sheriff, yet citizens when threatened could come together, cooperate long enough to deal with the threat, and then go back to their individual lives. Creating an armed force for a limited purpose was referred to as "getting up a posse." Such a procedure for dealing with threats is possible in international politics as well. It is known as collective security.

WHAT COLLECTIVE SECURITY IS

One must take care in using the phrase "collective security." It is a technical term, with a specific meaning, but it is often loosely used or even misused. Part of the trouble is that the meaning appears self-evident just by looking at the words. Another part of the trouble comes from deliberate misuse by people trying to win acceptance for other schemes that have nothing to do with collective security but look more attractive packaged under that label. Things such as military aid and peace time alliances have been given this label to win acceptance from a reluctant American public.

In its technical meaning collective security is a system of states that join together, usually by signing a treaty, and make an explicit commitment to do two things: (1) They renounce the use of force to settle disputes with each other, and (2) they promise to use force against any of their number who break rule 1. Notice that collective security shares with the balance of power the principle "meet force with opposing force," or "gang up on the aggressor." The aggressor should be deterred by the prospect of an overwhelming coalition. If deterrence fails, then the aggressor will be defeated by military action undertaken by this coalition.

Collective security applies only to what goes on inside the system; its purpose is to keep peace among its members, not to protect them against outsiders. For this reason, it was not proper to call a Cold War alliance such as the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) a collective security system. It was not the main purpose of NATO to defend Iceland from aggression by Britain (which would have been collective security, because they were both members of NATO), but to defend both Iceland and Britain against aggression by non-NATO countries.

NATO, the Warsaw Pact, and similar organizations were more properly called collective defense organizations or, simply, alliances. But alliances are specifically

ruled out among members of a collective security system. In such a system a state has no need to designate a few other states as especially trustworthy in case of need. According to collective security all other states in the system will automatically become allies in case of aggression. Alliances at any other time would only arouse suspicion.

Collective security makes it possible for states to renounce the use of force by assuring them that they will not be helpless if another state illegally uses force against them. At the same time, it requires that all states participate in sanctions against an aggressor. A policy of neutrality or isolation is not allowed.

Thus in two ways collective security is a move away from unrestricted state sovereignty toward the abolition of state sovereignty under world government. It forbids its members to resort to force to settle disputes and it requires them to use force to punish any member state that does. In these two ways it infringes on the traditional rights of sovereign states. But in all other respects states remain independent and sovereign. They are free to pursue other national interests, to enrich themselves, to compete for trade, and to run their domestic affairs as they see fit.

THE ADVANTAGES OF COLLECTIVE SECURITY

One advantage of collective security is that it guarantees the security of all states, big and small alike. By its explicit commitment to all states in the form of a treaty, it eliminates doubt about what will happen to any state that resorts to force for any reason whatsoever. Just as an individual citizen, no matter how weak, can feel secure in a civil society, so can the smallest state feel secure under collective security. An aggressor will face not just a single, weak victim but opposition from all the other states.

Another advantage of collective security is its simplicity. Use of force in interstate relations is simply outlawed. Disputes between states will undoubtedly continue to arise, but states will have to find peaceful ways of resolving them. The principle of collective security is not affected by the reasons for using force in any particular case, the background of the quarrel, or the probable consequences of defeat for one side or the other.

A collective security system is set up by a treaty or other agreement that identifies the members and describes the conditions under which it goes into operation. A typical formulation for the aggression that triggers a collective response is "violation of territorial integrity and political independence," although an agreement could be more limited than that. For example, in March 1935, Britain proposed a regional pact to prevent aerial warfare. According to this proposal (which remained hypothetical only), Britain, France, Germany, Italy, and Belgium would all agree that an unprovoked air attack by one on any other would trigger automatic massive retaliation against the violator by all the other countries.

This British plan lacked a feature that probably would have been added if it had come anywhere close to adoption—an organization to supervise it. Collective security systems need some kind of machinery to identify violations and coordinate efforts for defense. The most elaborate system of this kind was the League of Nations, which was set up after World War I. It was the first global organization whose primary task was preventing war. Its effective life ran from 1920 to 1936 and provides us with a case study of collective security in practice.

AN ATTEMPT TO IMPLEMENT COLLECTIVE SECURITY: THE LEAGUE OF NATIONS

In many ways the League of Nations was only a logical extension of practices that had developed before World War I. Conference diplomacy, by which all countries' delegates met in public assembly instead of in secret bilateral talks, had been used at the Hague Conferences in 1899 and 1907 to draw up rules for warfare. An international civil service, with bureaucrats owing loyalty to the world community rather than to a single country, was already running organizations such as the Universal Postal Union and the International Labor Organization. Even the essential feature of the League, the surrender of sovereignty in questions of war and peace, had been at least foreshadowed by the many alliances that committed states to go to war to aid others in specified circumstances. What made the League different was its universality. It was theoretically open to all states that would accept its obligations. In practice some states were rejected, in the beginning at least, on the argument that their governments were not democratic and therefore not subject to the effects of outraged public opinion if they chose to disregard collective security obligations. Germany was not yet considered rehabilitated in the eyes of the victors and was not allowed to join the League until 1926. Russia did not join until 1934. The majority of countries in Asia and Africa were not admitted because most were some kind of colonial dependents of European powers; even Ethiopia had a hard time getting accepted because the ruler was not able to govern his country effectively enough to abolish slavery. A major omission was the United States, not because it wasn't welcome but because the United States refused to approve ratification.

The founders of the League designed it according to what they thought were the lessons of World War I. Chief among these was the failure of the balance of power to prevent war. Instead of allowing themselves flexibility to realign against an aggressor, the great powers had let themselves be locked into two competing blocs. The remedy was collective security, which would rule out any alliance bloc until aggression was committed, at which time the aggressor would be automatically confronted by all other states. This principle of collective security was embodied in Article 16 of the Covenant of the League of Nations:

Article 16. 1. Should any Member of the League resort to war in disregard of its covenants . . . it shall, *ipso facto*, be deemed to have committed an act of war against other Members of the League.

The Latin phrase *ipso facto* means "by that fact"; in other words, the resort to force is considered an act of war no matter what the explanation.

Another lesson of World War I was that secret diplomacy and secret treaties made every country uncertain about what would happen if any country did use force. Therefore, founders of the League spoke of "open covenants openly arrived at." Any business that needed discussing could be discussed openly in the Assembly of the League of Nations. There was no need for secret treaties because a state could have only one alliance obligation in any case, to its collective security partners.

Another apparent lesson of World War I was the decisive importance of economic power. It was evident that the British and French had finally won the war when the Americans joined, not because the Americans were superior fighters but

because they were backed by industrial might. The Covenant therefore stressed economic sanctions against an aggressor. Article 16 goes on to state that if a country resorts to force, other members of the League would

undertake immediately to subject it to the severance of all trade or financial relations . . . and the prevention of all financial, commercial or personal intercourse between the nationals of the Covenant-breaking State and the nationals of any other State, whether a Member of the League or not.

It would take time to coordinate other sanctions, such as military ones, but in the meantime economic sanctions would be taking effect. It was widely expected that those alone would be enough to make an aggressor stop.

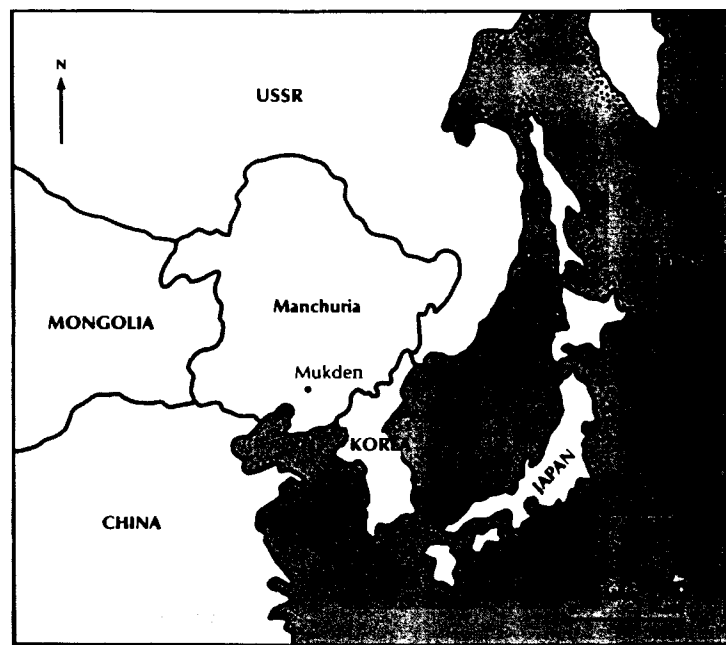
As conceived by President Woodrow Wilson, collective security was to be the opposite of balance of power politics, relying instead on moral pressure, and if that failed, economic sanctions.¹ Sanctions were seen as a humane alternative to war. But only to the nearsighted are economic sanctions humane. A total embargo affects an entire society, and within a society a bellicose leadership and a military establishment can protect itself from the effects of an embargo better than innocent civilians. Aggressor states already have their arms and armies. Only years of embargo will render them useless through wear and lack of spare parts. Food and fuel will run out first, and dwindling supplies will be allocated to "national security," not maternity hospitals and kindergartens.

The authors of the Covenant were vaguely aware of the effect on civilians of the blockade of Germany during World War I but tried to put it out of their minds, preferring to emphasize that their victory over Germany came on the battlefield. Direct attacks on uniformed soldiers were more valorous than the slow starvation of civilians. The Germans, however, had they been listened to, would have described the inhumane effects of the blockade.

In 1990 the world returned to the approach recommended by Woodrow Wilson and the League, applying economic sanctions to Iraq. The policy won wide support, being seen as a reasonable alternative to the "quagmire" of Vietnam (for the Americans) or Afghanistan (for the Russians) or to the "butcher bill" of previous wars. But only a month into the embargo a United Nations relief agency official in Amman warned: "How long will the Americans be able to hold to the embargo when the television news begins to show shots of hungry children?"² And indeed, even as Iraq continued to break its own word and deny UN inspection teams the right to investigate chemical, biological, and nuclear warfare installations, American newspapers were running photographs of malnourished Iraqi children.

HISTORY OF THE LEAGUE OF NATIONS

All these weaknesses of collective security were not yet apparent when the organization began to function in 1920. The first decade of the League passed without a decisive test of collective security. Some minor disputes were settled inside the League and some were ignored or settled outside the League.³ But the League was not confronted with a major international crisis that would test the theory and practice of collective security until the Manchurian crisis of 1931 (Map 13.1). Manchuria at this time, although nominally still part of China, was being exploited (in the economic sense) by its more powerful neighbors, chief of which was Japan. Japan already oc-



Map 13.1 Manchuria in 1931

cupied the neighboring territory of Korea and had leases on factories, mines, and railroads in Manchuria. The military party in Japan wanted to occupy all of Manchuria outright, annex it, exclude the growing number of Chinese emigrating from the southern part of China, and develop its industrial potential for Japan's benefit. This expansionist faction was well represented among the Japanese troops stationed in Manchuria to guard Japanese investments.

On September 18, 1931, a minor explosion occurred on a railroad line administered by the Japanese. Japanese troops stationed in the railroad zone blamed Chinese troops and immediately staged a suspiciously well-planned takeover of Chinese arsenals and garrisons in the area. Civilians in the Japanese government tried to control the military party while explaining to the world that this was only a local incident. At first the world was unaware of what was happening, because communications from such a distant area were slow and not very accurate and because the Japanese diplomats at the League headquarters in Geneva were themselves opposed to imperial expansion. Then on October 8, 1931, a hopelessly outclassed Chinese garrison decided to resist anyway, and the Japanese in angry retaliation bombed the city of Chinchow. Events in Manchuria had become impossible for the League to ignore. In response to Chinese protests, the League passed resolutions requesting that the Japanese withdraw, but the Japanese ignored them, continuing to expand their control until, on

February 18, 1932, they set up a puppet state to govern all of Manchuria, ostensibly a national liberation movement but obviously controlled by the Japanese.

The League reacted cautiously. It appointed a Commission of Inquiry in December 1931, which made a thorough investigation and issued a report of 100,000 words that was adopted by the League on February 24, 1933, that is, 17 months after the Japanese troops began their takeover. For all its length, the report's conclusions were quite simple. It concluded that "without any declaration of war, a large part of Chinese territory has been forcibly seized and occupied by Japanese troops."⁴ It would seem that China had been the victim of aggression and the League would come to China's aid. But, no, the League decided that because Japan had not declared war, Article 16 did not apply. All the League did was accept a suggestion by the commission that changes in territory made by armed force would not be recognized. In other words, the only penalty applied to Japan would be that the postage stamps and currency of the puppet state would not be accepted by other countries. This moral condemnation of the Japanese merely angered them without in any way making them change their behavior. The next month they announced their withdrawal from the League.

The Manchurian crisis revealed a basic feature of the League's collective security system. Theoretically all states would participate in sanctions against an aggressor. In practice, some states would have to bear a bigger burden than others. Japan was an island nation in the Pacific, part of the "Far East" in European eyes. Enforcing an embargo (or stronger action) would require considerable power. Of the League members, only Britain had the kind of power—naval power—that could be projected into this region, and British leaders agreed that an expedition in Asia would distract attention and divert energy from Europe, where the real danger to their security would come from. The United States, also a naval power and with more direct interests in this area, was not a member of the League, and the isolationist mood that had kept it from joining the League continued strong. The only other state capable of acting in this area was Russia, but it was not yet a League member and was in any case preoccupied with domestic disorder brought on by the forced collectivization of the peasantry. Russia chose instead to pursue an appeasement policy with Japan, granting de facto recognition to the puppet state in March 1935. Manchuria was in Japan's sphere of influence and no major power chose to challenge it.

The next major crisis to confront the League came from Latin America. Conflict between Bolivia and Paraguay over 100,000 square miles of an uninhabited river basin known as the Chaco turned into full-scale war in 1932 (Map 13.2). The League tried to impose sanctions in the form of an arms embargo but did not succeed in stopping shipments of arms until August 1934. Rapid action by the U.S. Congress at this time suddenly made an arms embargo possible. American opinion had been aroused by advertisements of U.S. armaments companies in a Bolivian newspaper, and Congress unanimously gave the president power to prohibit sales of arms and munitions to Bolivia and Paraguay. By this time the two countries were coming to realize that neither of them could win in any case, and in June 1935 they allowed other American states to work out a peace. As in the case of Manchuria, the dispute occurred in the sphere of influence of one power (the United States) and only if that power chose to act was the League able to act. The United States was not the aggressor,

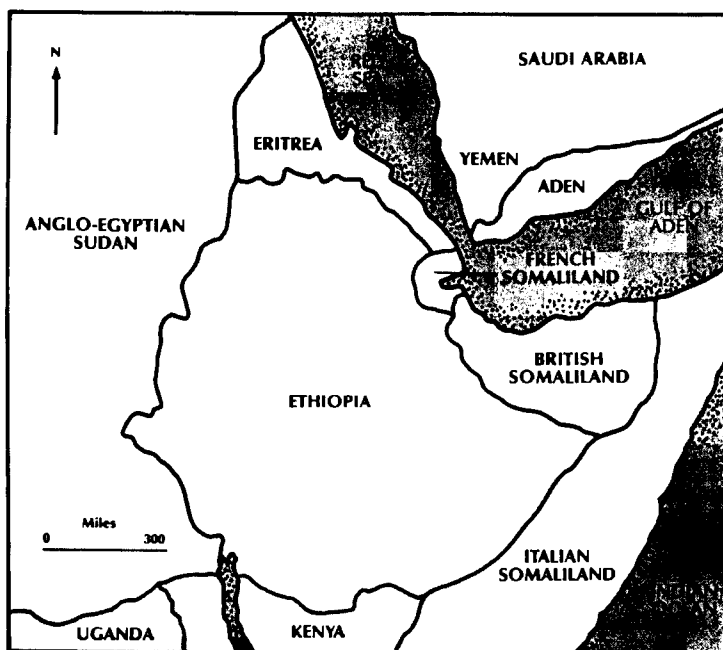


Map 13.2 The Gran Chaco

as Japan was, but the inability of outsiders to intrude in a great power's sphere of influence was similar.

The third major crisis that the League confronted was too much for it and led to its collapse. The crisis involved Abyssinia, or, as it is called today, Ethiopia. (Map 13.3.) Italy, which already controlled a colony in the neighboring territory of Eritrea, had wanted for decades to extend its control to Ethiopia, one of the few remaining territories in Africa not controlled by Europeans. The Italians had tried to take over Ethiopia at the end of the nineteenth century but failed, suffering a humiliating defeat at the battle of Adowa in 1896. Forty years later Mussolini wanted to avenge that defeat and demonstrate the new Italian renaissance under Fascism. Italy's ambitions in the 1930s were not different from France's and Britain's in the preceding century when they had occupied territory in Africa. The Italians just came too late in history. Ethiopia was no longer "unoccupied" territory but a fully recognized sovereign state and a member of the League of Nations.

But Italy was not ashamed to be pursuing nineteenth-century aims in the twentieth century and made no effort to hide its intentions. Preparations for invasion in Eritrea were obvious. Italy employed thousands of laborers to build roads, docks, and airfields. Several million tons of equipment were stockpiled. Natives of Eritrea were mobilized for military training. Reserves in Italy were called up.



Map 13.3 Ethiopia in 1935

In December 1934, Italian troops clashed with Ethiopians. According to the Italians the clash was a border dispute, although even according to the Italians' military maps the Italians were 80 miles inside Ethiopia. In January 1935, Emperor Haile Selassie of Ethiopia appealed to the League for support. But because the 1934 clash was only a military engagement, not an attempt to seize territory, League members felt there were no grounds for action under the doctrine of collective security. Even though Ethiopia felt threatened by 500,000 Italian troops massing across its border, the Italians had committed no overt aggression.

Having prepared without hindrance, Italy launched its attack in October, 1935. The League within a week found that Italy had resorted to war and ten days later voted to apply sanctions against Italy. These were to include an embargo on arms, new loans and bank credits, and all imports from Italy. But the League could not bring itself to embargo the one commodity essential to Italy's invasion of Ethiopia, namely oil. Furthermore, the League did not insist on the closure of the Suez Canal, which would have cut Italy's supply line. No one even breathed the possibility of military action against Italy in defense of Ethiopia.

This failure to take decisive steps against Italy was grounded in the belief of the other major powers in the League that Germany posed a bigger threat to their own security and Italy might be needed at some future point as an ally. Thus, to avoid alienating Italy, the British Foreign Minister Samuel Hoare and the French premier Pierre

Laval had even worked out a solution whereby Italy could keep control of half of Ethiopia, under the pretext of administering it for the League. Even when the Hoare-Laval plan leaked to the public in December, 1935, it did not generate enough outrage to force the League to take sterner measures. The limited sanctions that had been applied were not enough to make Italy stop. In fact, they had the unintended effect of uniting the majority of the Italian people behind Mussolini for the first time since he took office. Italy went on to win the war against Ethiopia, using airplanes and poison gas among other modern weapons. Emperor Haile Selassie fled the country and personally addressed the League Assembly in Geneva in May 1936, a living reproach to its cowardice and passivity. "God and history will remember your judgement," he told them.⁵ In July 1936 the League acknowledged its own moral bankruptcy by lifting even the limited sanctions. Later it even recognized Italian sovereignty over Ethiopia.

REASONS FOR THE FAILURE OF THE LEAGUE

The Ethiopian crisis marked the death of collective security as practiced by the League of Nations. The League's failures in this crisis illustrate some of its structural weaknesses. One problem was that nobody quite trusted it. The great powers gave lip service to the new idea of collective security but secretly they still believed in the old idea of the balance of power. Britain and France did not want to push Italy too hard because they thought they might need Italy as an ally in a future conflict with Germany. With the benefit of hindsight we know that this hope was vain and that Italy and Germany fought on the same side in World War II, but it was not obvious to diplomats in 1935 that this "Berlin-Rome Axis" was going to come into being. The issue of the South Tyrol, inhabited by Germans and ruled by Italians, was widely believed to be an insurmountable obstacle to German-Italian cooperation. The same sort of calculation paralyzed the League in the Manchurian crisis. Preparing a defense against Germany in Europe was more important to Britain and France than the abstract principle of opposing aggression no matter where it occurred. In the abstract, perhaps, peace was "indivisible," but when their own peace was threatened, states reverted to old-fashioned calculations of balance of power.

The behavior of the smaller members of the League was no more virtuous. Those states in favor of applying sanctions against Italy in the Ethiopian crisis were mostly countries close to Italy that feared an expansion of its power—Czechoslovakia, Rumania, Yugoslavia, Greece, and Turkey. But other countries in this area supported Italy, not because they thought Italy was in the right in Ethiopia but for reasons of self-interest. Austria shared with Italy a fear of Germany. Albania and to some extent Hungary were client states dependent on Italy. Other states in more distant parts of the world (Scandinavia, Latin America) saw little of direct interest to themselves in the crisis.

Perhaps the attitude of the smaller members would have been less important if all the major states had been members. But Japan had by this time quit the League as a result of the Manchurian crisis and Germany had left the League over the issue of rearmament. (Germany felt it would benefit no matter how the Ethiopian crisis was resolved. Either Italy would be defeated and a potential rival cut down, enabling Hitler to recover the South Tyrol, or the Western democracies would demonstrate their impotence and Germany could make gains elsewhere.) But the most serious

omission was the absence of the United States. Even if oil products had been included in the League embargo, profit-seeking companies in the United States would have been glad to send its oil to Italy to make up what they were being denied from League members. League members probably would not have risked interference with U.S. ships to enforce an embargo.

The ability of a single country effectively to undermine the embargo of all the others reveals the weakness of the belief in the automatic success of economic sanctions. In the absence of unanimous support for an embargo, some kind of force must be used to make it work. An embargo must be turned into a blockade, and because so much of world trade moves by sea (three-quarters in the case of Italy in 1936), a blockade means reliance on naval power. Only a navy could deny supplies to Italy, and in 1936 only Britain had a navy capable of doing the job. But the British admiralty was justifiably worried about the consequences of modern military technology for their navy. In 1924 a U.S. advocate of air power, General Billy Mitchell, had demonstrated the vulnerability of ships by sinking old battleships off Cape Hatteras. The British did not want their navy to confirm these experimental results in actual combat.

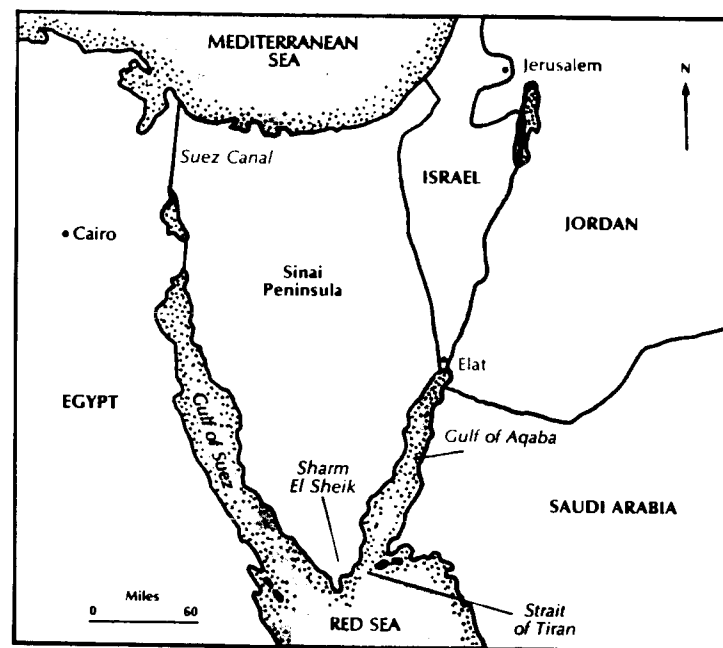
WEAKNESSES OF COLLECTIVE SECURITY

The failure of the League of Nations can be seen as the result of the historical situation in which it had to operate, particularly the harsh Versailles peace settlement that encouraged the rise of Hitler and the failure of the United States to play a major role in world politics. But troublesome as these problems were, the League also suffered fundamental difficulties with any collective security system.

One problem is the definition of "aggression." A collective security system needs explicit and unambiguous criteria on which to act. The existence of such criteria is one way in which it contrasts with the balance of power. Under the balance of power mere suspicion of another country's intentions might be enough to justify a preventive war. But the need for a legal definition leads collective security to concentrate on overt acts, such as sending troops in uniform over a demarcated frontier. Thus when Haile Selassie became alarmed at Italian preparations for invasion in January 1935, he could not get the League to act, not only because its members were reluctant to oppose Italy but also because Italy had not yet done anything to violate the Covenant of the League. Likewise, the best way to have headed off World War II would have been to have done something about German rearmament, beginning in 1935. But any League action would have been interference in the internal affairs of a sovereign state. As a result of the need to adhere to legal definitions, when wars did break out, they were much bigger and the aggressor was much harder to defeat.

States have found it impossible to arrive at an unambiguous definition of aggression. The classic formulation of "violation of territorial integrity and political independence" is not always adequate. Hitler's occupation of the demilitarized zone along the Rhineland in 1936 violated both the Versailles treaty and the Locarno treaty, but the Rhineland was German territory. Hitler's annexation of Austria in 1938 extinguished the political independence of Austria, but it was supposedly at the request of the Austrian government.

More recent cases are even more ambiguous. In May 1967, Egypt closed the Strait of Tiran to ships going to the Israeli port of Elat, thereby cutting off Israel's



Map 13.4 The Strait of Tiran

trade (including oil) with Asia. (Map 13.4.) In response, Israel attacked Egypt. Which country was the aggressor? Egypt was blocking an Israeli port, and a blockade has traditionally been considered an act of war. By this criterion Egypt started the 1967 war. But Egypt claimed it was merely excluding ships from its own territorial waters, and such action was not an act of war. States do not agree on the legal issue. The Strait of Tiran is a place where ships must pass through the territorial waters of a state (Egypt) to get from one international body of water (the Red Sea) to another (the Gulf of Aqaba). A rule of international law called the "right of innocent passage" was included in a convention on the law of the sea drawn up at Geneva in 1958. That convention has been accepted by many states, but not by Egypt.

After years of trying to define aggression, in 1974 the UN issued a definition covering many kinds of behavior—invasion, bombardment of territory, blockade of ports, attack on armed forces, and sending terrorists. But the usefulness of definition was badly weakened by two loopholes. One was that "acts enumerated above are not exhaustive and the Security Council may determine that other acts constitute aggression under the provision of the Charter."⁶ In other words, aggression is whatever the Security Council says it is. Given a Council with the right political composition, Egypt could find support for Gamal Abdel Nasser's statement that the very existence of the state of Israel is an act of aggression.

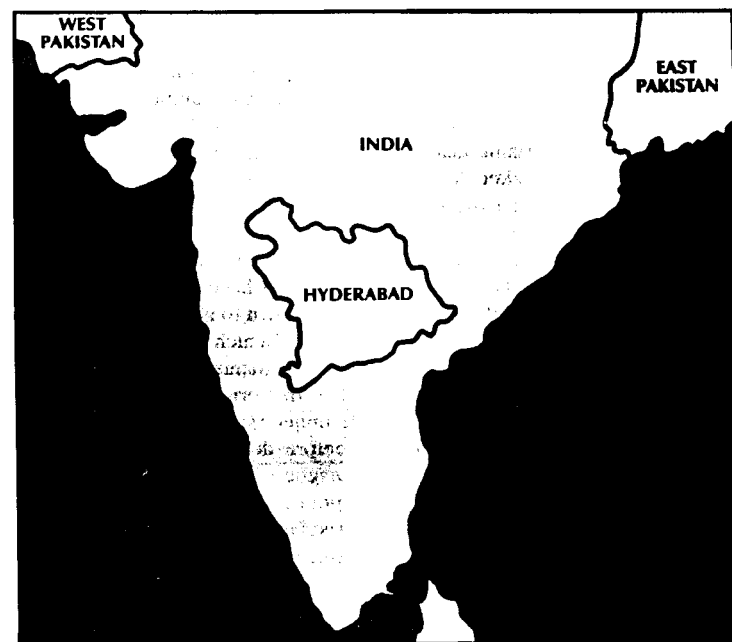
This loophole expands the definition of aggression. A second loophole contracts it. It states that "nothing in this definition could in any way prejudice the right to self-determination, freedom and independence of peoples forcibly deprived of that right, particularly peoples under colonial and racist regimes or other forms of alien domination; nor the right of these people to struggle to that end and to seek and receive support, in accordance with the principles of the Charter." In other words, when Indian troops crossed the frontier into Goa in 1961, they were not committing an act of aggression, because people forcibly deprived of the right of self-determination were seeking and receiving support in their struggle to that end. Using this definition, one might argue that the North Korean attack of 1950 was not aggression but an act of national self-determination.

A second problem with collective security is the requirement that all states participate in actions against an aggressor. It doesn't much matter if one or two minor states refuse to join in enforcement action, but participation by major states is essential. If power is not evenly distributed among the members of a collective security system, then refusal by even one or two of the major states to cooperate may doom any attempt at enforcement. In practice it may be difficult to get even a majority of states to participate in action against an aggressor. States will be reluctant to act against other states if those states are very powerful neighbors, or long-standing allies, or the perceived victims. In 1935, Albania would not oppose its powerful protector Italy; in 1950 the Soviet Union would not oppose its ideological ally North Korea; in 1967 many states would not blame Israel for initiating hostilities.

Furthermore, states will be reluctant to make sacrifices for quarrels that seem remote. In September 1948, Indian troops invaded the state of Hyderabad to force it to join the Republic of India (Map 13.5). Hyderabad appealed to the UN but its appeal was ignored. No member of the UN felt threatened because no member saw itself as another candidate for incorporation into the new Indian state. Hyderabad had been part of the British colonial possession of India and was totally surrounded by states that had joined the new Republic of India. No other state was in a similar position and thus no other state felt itself threatened by this precedent.

The UN did come to the defense of South Korea in 1950. At first glance this appears to be collective security in action, with states from many parts of the world coming to the aid of a small, remote country under attack. But in fact the North Korean invasion aroused the United States not so much because of concern for the abstract principle of collective security (after all, the United States had not reacted to the Indian invasion of Hyderabad two years earlier) as because of interest in neighboring Japan, which was then under American occupation. European countries supported action in Korea because they saw an analogy with Germany, where the Communist half of a divided country was also preparing for reunification by force. They believed that by showing resolve in Korea they might deter a Communist attack in Europe.

The theoretical requirement of collective security that all states take part in actions against an aggressor is often justified by the claim that "peace is indivisible." That is, peace in each country is threatened by war anywhere. Conflict in distant parts of the world cannot be walled off and ignored. The indivisibility of the peace is often contrasted favorably with the appeasement policy of Britain before World War II, when Chamberlain argued against helping Czechoslovakia because the Sudetenland



Map 13.5 Hyderabad in 1947

crisis was a "quarrel in a faraway country between people of whom we know nothing."⁷ The British of course found themselves shortly thereafter at war, and Chamberlain's statement has been ridiculed ever since.

Traumatic as the Munich experience was for Europeans and Americans, it may be an error to make too much of this single example. In fact not all small disputes lead to larger ones. India's annexation of Goa in 1961 was not a prelude to Indian world conquest. Whatever the justice of the settlement, to either the Portuguese, who were deprived of their territory by armed force, or the native Goans, who were never consulted on their preferences but seemed in fact to prefer Portuguese rule, that conflict did not bring the world to the brink of war.

In recent years the belief in the "indivisible peace" has taken the form of the domino theory. U.S. intervention in Vietnam was originally defended as necessary to prevent neighboring countries from going communist. Dwight D. Eisenhower had noted in his diary, even before becoming president, that it was important for the French to maintain control in Vietnam, for "if they quit and Indochina falls to Communies, it is easily possible that the countries of Southeast Asia and Indonesia would go, soon to be followed by India."⁸ At a press conference in April 1954 Eisenhower said, "You have a row of dominoes set up, you knock over the first one, and what will happen to the last one is the certainty that it will go over very quickly. So you

could have a beginning of a disintegration that would have profound consequences.⁹

In fact Eisenhower's worst fears came true and the Communists did take over in 1975, yet only Vietnam's small weak neighbors of Laos and Cambodia followed it into the Communist bloc. Furthermore, 15 years later that bloc itself had dissolved and the communist victory in Cambodia was undone by a UN-negotiated agreement. The long, costly Vietnam war to keep dominos from falling had been unnecessary.

One might ask whether the solution offered by the balance of power system wasn't better: Instead of trying to prevent all conflicts, isolate them when they occur in remote parts of the world. The South Americans fought a number of destructive wars in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries (the Chaco War, the War of the Pacific, the War of La Plata) but these are almost unknown to North Americans because the conflicts were isolated by the Monroe Doctrine, which kept Europeans out, and did not become world wars. They were nobody's Vietnams.

Another difficulty with collective security is that organizations by their very nature react slowly to crises. First it must be determined who is at fault. War is a serious matter and states must be sure of the facts before they engage in belligerent acts against aggressors. It is easy to criticize the League for its ponderous efforts in the Manchurian crisis, but communications were poor and information spotty. Even the Japanese government was not sure of what was happening. Critics always have the benefit of hindsight. The aggression of Iraq against Kuwait in 1990 was exceptional in its clarity. Ten years earlier in the same part of the world the origins of the war between Iraq and Iran were shrouded in obscurity. In that war Iraqi troops crossed the border first but claimed that Iranian artillery had been shelling them. The 1980 situation is more typical than the 1990 one.

Because under collective security no action may be taken unless actual acts of aggression occur, no advance planning is possible merely on the basis of suspicion. This means that an aggressor has an enormous advantage. An aggressor can plan for months or even years, carry through a move with lightning speed, and then present the world with a fait accompli. The collective security organization then has the unpleasant choice of accepting the results of aggression or mounting a massive campaign that will cause destruction all out of proportion to the violation. The example of Kuwait is instructive. Had the country not been one of the richest in the world, the destruction caused by the Persian Gulf War would have been all out of proportion to any possible gain from being liberated. Even with their high per capita income the Kuwaitis' recovery was slow and painful.

The fait accompli is an effective tactic. Because modern means of warfare such as missiles and airplanes threaten civilian as well as military targets, states are reluctant to expose their own populations to attack to undo the results of aggression elsewhere. They are tempted to redefine aggression to exclude such acts and let the results stand. Had Iraqi Scuds carried nuclear warheads, more than one state within their range might have been willing to give serious consideration to Iraq's claim that it was merely reclaiming a historic province when it annexed Kuwait.

Other recent wars in the Middle East in 1967, on the Indian subcontinent in 1971, and on the island of Cyprus in 1974 illustrate this problem as well. Israel, India, and Turkey each carried out rapid military operations, which were completed before the world could react. The task of reversing the results of these operations was so

massive that the results were allowed to stand. One or more countries continued to protest against the results of these quick operations, but no one expected countries of the world to combine in military operations to undo them. One can argue that the UN is not a true collective security organization, so its members had no legal obligation to act in any of these three cases. But even if there had been such an organization, you can see the difficulties its members would have confronted when faced with such faits accomplis, and this was true even though none of these states at the time had nuclear forces.

Only rarely is an act of aggression so blatant as Iraq's annexation of Kuwait in August, 1990. At the time many observers expected Saddam Hussein to seek to divide the coalition against him by a conciliatory gesture, such as withdrawing from much of Kuwait but retaining portions of Kuwait's oil fields. Had he done so, it is unlikely a war against him would have found much support. Even with his uncompromising stand, many observers doubted that the coalition could maintain sanctions for long, an important factor in President Bush's decision to press for war.

Finally, like so many plans for peace, collective security preserves the status quo and thus works to the advantage of states that benefit most from the status quo. An ironclad collective security agreement would be like a poker game interrupted in the middle when one player is far ahead. Gambling is suddenly declared illegal but the player who is ahead is allowed to keep his or her winnings.

Furthermore, so long as the principle of noninterference in internal affairs is observed, groups such as the Bengalis will have to suffer whatever a dominant ethnic group subjects them to. Going to their aid would be interference in internal affairs and thus aggression. For this reason, the UN definition of aggression, even with its enormous loopholes, is more realistic than a rigid one would be, for it reflects the need to have ways of changing the status quo. But one problem with such elastic definitions is that they provide no assurance to any state that it will receive support if another state uses force against it. The same African states that opposed the use of force to aid the Ibo people of Nigeria in their war to set up an independent state in 1967 encouraged the use of force against the Portuguese colonies in Mozambique and Angola. Winning support as a victim of aggression is more the result of having enough political supporters than of any objective conditions such as having enemy troops cross your frontier.

REGIONAL COLLECTIVE SECURITY

Both theory and practice suggest that collective security will not work on the global level. But it might have a chance in more limited areas, where differences between states are not so great. Some people have advocated more emphasis on organizations that limit their membership to states in a geographic region of the world. We call this approach to peace *regional collective security*.

Like all collective security systems, a regional one would try to preserve peace only among its members. It would create an island of peace in a world where great power rivalry, ideological struggles, and competition for resources might continue to cause conflict elsewhere. In this way regionalism reverses a basic tenet of supporters of the League of Nations that peace was indivisible, because the idea rests on the assumption that one region of the world can be sealed off from the rest of the world.¹⁰

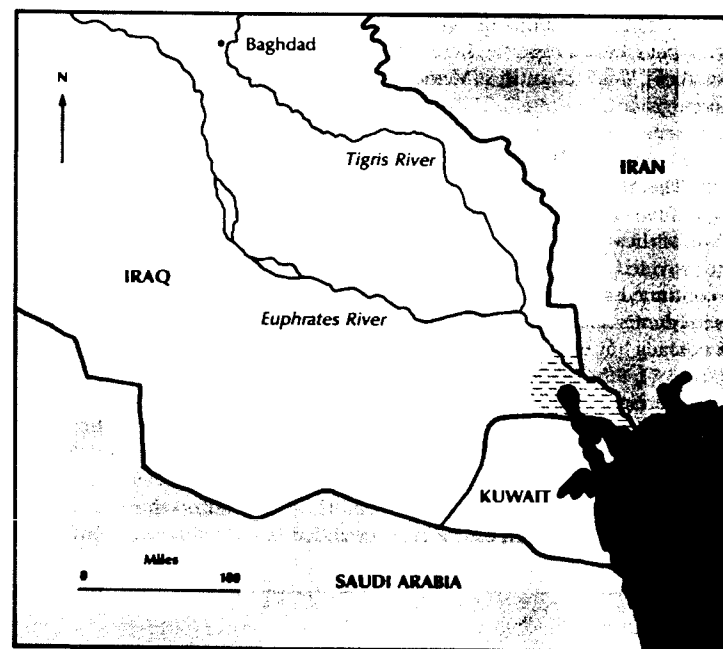
By this argument, regional organizations will have more success in maintaining peace among their members because these members are more likely to have common interests. They may have similar resources (such as oil or coffee) or similar problems (such as tribal divisions). These similarities will enable them to understand regional disputes better and come up with appropriate solutions, and such solutions are more likely to be heeded coming from sympathetic sources.

In many parts of the world numerous state boundaries are the result of artificial divisions between imperialist powers. Syria and Jordan are separate countries mainly because France administered one and Britain the other. A world organization is too big and unwieldy to deal with problems arising from such divisions; individual states by themselves cannot handle them either. Only at the regional level can realistic solutions be found, argue the regionalists. Also, confining the business of maintaining peace to the regional level provides a good excuse for excluding major powers. Even states fearful of expansionist neighbors might not want outside assistance if they would have to pay the price of massive destruction that Vietnam did.

Although no regional organizations exist strictly for collective security, a number have the potential and have taken some actions in the name of preserving peace. Typical of these is the Organization of African Unity (OAU). It was founded in 1963 and is open to all independent states on the continent of Africa. Outsiders are excluded from membership, and its primary goal is solving problems within the region, not providing protection for members against external enemies. Other organizations in this category are the Arab League, formed in 1945 and gradually increasing its membership as more Arab states became independent, and the Organization of American States (OAS), formed in 1948.

The role once foreseen for regional organizations is illustrated by a conflict more than three decades ago between two former British possessions in the Middle East, Iraq and Kuwait (see Map 13.6). Iraq became independent in 1936, but the British retained Kuwait as a protectorate until 1961. As independence for Kuwait approached, the Iraqis laid claim to it as a former province. Unwilling to be absorbed, Kuwait asked the British to station troops. After several meetings the Arab League decided to admit Kuwait as a member, thereby giving increased legitimacy to its claim to exist as a sovereign, independent state. Iraq alone resisted. Meanwhile the Arabs, eager to be rid of a British military presence, sent troops of their own to replace the British in Kuwait. A force of 3,300 from five Arab countries backed up the Arab League's decision to recognize Kuwait's sovereignty by giving it protection against Iraq. Iraq appeared to give up its opposition to an independent Kuwait in 1963, although events three decades later showed how powerful even long dormant irredentist claims can be.

Part of the reason regionalism was viewed optimistically was that it conformed nicely with a widespread desire in the United States to reduce American responsibility in other parts of the world. If regional organizations worked better anyhow, then we could do what we wanted and be virtuous at the same time. President Nixon expressed this view in his "State of the World" message of 1971: "It is no longer possible to . . . argue that security or development around the globe is primarily America's concern. The defense and progress of other countries must be first their responsibility and second a regional responsibility."¹¹



Map 13.6 Iraq and Kuwait

THE EXPERIENCE OF REGIONAL ORGANIZATIONS

Events during the decade following Nixon's speech struck severe blows to the hopes of regionalism. The most important regional organizations suffered major setbacks in their attempts to keep peace. Although the Arab League made some contribution to the settlement of the Kuwait problem in 1963, it failed to resolve any subsequent conflicts. Its ineffectiveness was made clear following Iraq's invasion of Kuwait in 1990. Despite rhetoric about the need to find "an Arab solution," the organization was sharply divided into two camps. In the end, several of the Arab states joined with outsiders such as the United States, Britain, and France in war against a fellow League member.

Some modest success might be claimed for the OAS in containing the 1979 civil war in Nicaragua. Although the OAS did little to limit the violence of the war itself, which caused over 20,000 deaths, just its existence may have inhibited the Nicaraguan government from retaliating against its unarmed neighbor, Costa Rica, for providing sanctuary for guerrillas. (When Nicaraguan planes did strafe targets over the border, Panama and Venezuela provided military assistance to Costa Rica—although on their own, not as the result of an OAS decision.)

In the subsequent violence in Central America, the OAS played almost no role at all. El Salvador fought a civil war, charging that the insurgents were armed by neighboring Nicaragua. Nicaragua in turn charged that forces based in Honduras